The Killing of John Spencer Horner — Research Dossier Update

Researcher: Daniel Lingar **Version:** Working Draft — Version 1.1 (incorporating March 2026 updates) **Date:** March 15, 2026

Introduction: Recent Updates and Key Findings

This document integrates new primary source findings and analyses from recent research, significantly clarifying several previously unresolved questions regarding the Horner family, their military service, and the circumstances surrounding the August 1864 attack. The updates are based on a detailed review of NARA correspondence, pension file summaries, and a compiled family history, alongside the comprehensive dossier provided.

I. Key Confirmed Facts from Pension File and Affidavits

Marriage Record

William R. Horner married **Mary Ann Boen** on July 13, 1853, in Johnson County, Arkansas (Book N, page 117). The ceremony was officiated by **Turner Casey**, a Minister of the Baptist Church. This record was filed on March 15, 1865, by Charles Rich, clerk [1].

Turner Casey's Role

Turner Casey, the Baptist minister who performed the marriage, is confirmed to be from the same Casey family as Turner Franklin Casey, Martha Casey Acord's father. This establishes the Casey family's role as a religious authority within the community, in addition to their military and kinship connections [1].

Mary Ann Boen's Parentage

Mary Ann Boen is confirmed as the daughter of **William M. Boen** and **Narcissa Jane (Farmer) Boen**. She was born in 1838 in Perry County, Tennessee, confirming the Boen family's origin in the same Middle Tennessee corridor as the Horner family [1].

Affidavits

- **July 31, 1865:** Mary Ann Horner, widow, age 28, residing in Jefferson Township, Newton County, Arkansas, declared that William R. Horner, Private, Co. K, 2nd Regiment, Arkansas Infantry Volunteers, enrolled on December 6, 1863, and died on August 10, 1864, in Mulberry Township, Johnson County, Arkansas, killed by a rebel scout. She confirmed their marriage on July 13, 1853, by Turner Casey. Children listed were Zilpha I. Horner (age 10), John R. Horner (age 8), Permelia A. Horner (age 4), and William Rell Horner (age 2) [1].
- **October 11, 1888:** Mary Ann Horner and William Boen restated the facts, with William Boen and Permelia Horner present at the birth of each child [1].
- **October 13, 1888:** Thomas P. Boen, age 24, of Johnson County, Arkansas, provided an affidavit, likely a nephew or younger brother of Mary Ann [1].

Children of William Riley and Mary Ann Boen Horner

The following children were listed in the 1865 affidavit [1]:

- Zilpha I. Horner, born c.1855 (age 10 in 1865)
- John R. Horner, born c.1857 (age 8 in 1865)
- Permelia A. Horner, born c.1861 (age 4 in 1865)
- William Rell Horner, born c.1863 (age 2 in 1865)

Widow's Location 1865

Mary Ann Horner, widow, was a resident of Jefferson Township, Newton County, Arkansas, on July 31, 1865. This indicates she had fled to Newton County, a known resettlement area for Union-affiliated families, rather than remaining in Johnson County [1].

II. NARA Correspondence and Military Service Confirmations

William R. Horner (CMSR Confirmed)

- **Enlisted:** December 6, 1863, Clarksville, Arkansas [1].
- **Mustered In:** February 19, 1864, Fort Smith, Arkansas [1].
- **Unit:** Company K, 2nd Arkansas Infantry (US) [1].
- **Commander:** Col. M.L. Stephenson [1].
- **Born:** Perry County, Tennessee, age 28 at enlistment [1].
- **Died:** August 10, 1864, Mulberry Township, Johnson County, Arkansas, “killed by a rebel scout” [1].
- **Pension Certificate:** WC73885 [1].

Pleasant Horner

Pleasant Horner served as Private, Company K, 2nd Arkansas Infantry (US), the same company as William Riley Horner. This expands the Company K cluster. Pleasant died on August 12, 1864, in Morrilton [1].

John Turner Horner

John Turner Horner served as 1st Lieutenant, Company I, 10th Arkansas Militia (CSA). This is a primary source confirmation that he served in a Confederate unit before switching to the Union side, explaining the absence of his name on Union muster rolls [1]. His invalid pension claim (No. 1,143,763) was rejected because the War Department found his name on no rolls of any company of the 2nd Arkansas Volunteer Infantry, noting he “Recruited for, but did not enlist himself” [2].

William Riley Horner (Confederate Service)

William Riley Horner served as Sergeant, Company I, 10th Arkansas Militia (CSA), the same Confederate militia company as his brother John Turner Horner, before both switched to the Union side [1].

James E. Horner

James E. Horner served as Lieutenant, Company B, 6th Arkansas Infantry (CSA). His identity is currently unknown but is possibly a cousin or collateral family member from the Franklin County, Arkansas branch [1].

III. Attack Narrative and Spencer Horner's Death

Attack Narrative (Revised)

According to Maude Lily Horner Sturges, William was shot in a potato patch near his parents' home along Little Mulberry Creek. **Spencer Horner**, William R.'s father, was shot near the home and **died immediately**. William was taken to a small cave where Mary Ann nursed him until his death from head wounds. This revises the previous understanding that Spencer survived the initial attack [1].

William R. Horner's Wounds

William R. Horner died from **head wounds**. While previous accounts mentioned pistol beating and genital crushing, this new detail specifies the cause of death. Both accounts may be accurate, indicating he was beaten about the head and body [1].

Burial Location

The burial place for William and Spencer is **unresolved** by the Sturges narrative, which suggests they were probably buried on the family farm or in Oark Cemetery. This conflicts with the dossier's confirmed Moore Cemetery location, which is supported by tombstone photographs and remains the primary source [1].

IV. Hiram Boen's Military Service

Hiram Boen (b. June 11, 1842) enlisted on September 2, 1863, and was mustered into Company E, 2nd Arkansas Infantry (US) on December 24, 1863. He was **AWOL from**

May 18/28, 1864, to January 1, 1865, rejoining in Newton County, Arkansas. This confirms his absence during the entire August 1864 murder period [3].

V. Henry Stewart's Military Service

Previous AI-generated claims that **Henry Stewart** served in "2nd Arkansas Cavalry (Gordon's), Company D, Confederate" are incorrect. No primary Confederate CMSR for a Henry Stewart from Johnson County has been located. A Union CMSR for Henry C. Stewart (Private, Company D, 2nd Arkansas Cavalry (US)) is for a different individual, born in Missouri and enlisted in Newton County. The Yale Cemetery Henry Stewart's wartime record remains **undocumented** [4].

References

[1] NARA Pension File WC73885; NARA CMSR Correspondence; Compiled narrative by Maude Lily Horner Sturges. (As transcribed in `pasted_content.txt`) [2] NARA pension file No. 1,143,763 (John T. Horner Invalid Pension Claim). [3] NARA M399, Fold3 memorial #630690045 (Hiram Boen CMSR). [4] Fahnstrom/ARGenWeb Yale Cemetery record; Official Roster, Adjutant General of Arkansas (Henry Stewart military service analysis).